

Ballota nigra (Lamiaceae) Black Horehound

Description Straggling perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has oval, toothed leaves and pink-purple flowers in whorls at the base of the upper leaves.

Habitat & Cultivation This herb is found throughout much of Europe, in North America, and in Asia. It thrives in open areas, in pavement cracks, and by roadsides, mostly near human habitation. It is harvested when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Black horehound contains diterpenoids, including marrubiin, flavonoids, tannins, saponins, and a volatile oil.

History & Folklore The Greek physician Dioscorides, writing in the 1st century CE, recommends a plaster of black horehound leaves and salt for dog bites. He also advocates a balm, made from the dried leaves and honey, to purify infected wounds and ulcers.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though long considered a remedy for convulsions, low spirits, and menopausal problems, black horehound is rarely used today. Authorities differ over whether there is any substance to claims for its earlier applications. The herb is currently used by Anglo-American herbalists as an antiemetic—preventing or reducing nausea or vomiting. It is perhaps most useful when nausea arises from disorders of the inner ear (such

as Ménière's disease) as opposed to those of the digestive system. Black horehound is thought to be mildly sedative and antispasmodic, and is occasionally taken for arthritis and gout.

Bambusa arundinaceae (Poaceae)

Spiny Bamboo

Description Perennial tree, up to 100 ft (30 m), with multiple stems from its base. Has narrow pointed leaves and long loose clusters of yellow to yellowish-green flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Found throughout tropical Asia, especially in India and China, spiny bamboo thrives up to 6,900 ft (2,100 m) above sea level.

Parts Used Root, leaves, sprouts.

Constituents Spiny bamboo juice contains high levels of silica.

History & Folklore Spiny bamboo is arguably the most useful plant on earth, being used to make scaffolding, rafts, furniture, paper, and dozens of other items. It also has an important role to play in herbal medicine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Various parts of spiny bamboo are used in Indian and Ayurvedic medicine. The root is considered astringent and cooling, and is used to treat joint pain and general debility. The leaves are used to stimulate menstruation, and, being antispasmodic, to help relieve period pain. They are also taken to tone and strengthen stomach function and to expel worms. They are reputed to be aphrodisiac. The young sprouts are eaten to relieve nausea, indigestion, and gas, and a poultice of the sprouts is applied to help drain wounds that have become infected. The juice is rich in silica, and aids in the strengthening of cartilage in conditions such as osteoarthritis and osteoporosis.

Related Species In Chinese herbal medicine, the juice and shavings of the black bamboo (*B. breviflora*) are prescribed to counter "excess heat," coughs, and a congested chest. Its roots are used as a diuretic and to treat fevers.

Banisteriopsis caapi (Malpighiaceae)

Ayahuasca

Description Woody vine growing to 100 ft (30 m). Has smooth bark, oval leaves, and bunches of small red or yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Ayahuasca is native to jungles of the Amazon basin. It is cultivated by indigenous peoples, but the wild herb is preferred for medicinal use.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Ayahuasca contains beta-carboline alkaloids (including harmine, harmaline, and delta-tetrahydroharmine), which stimulate hallucinations.

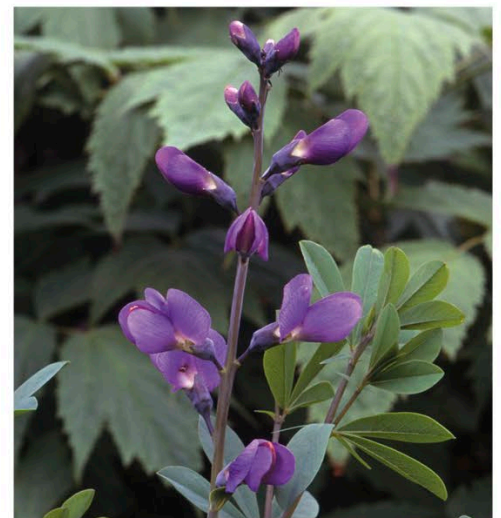
History & Folklore In the Quechua language, *ayahuasca* means "spirit of the dead," indicating the awesome powers traditionally attributed to this plant. Another native Indian name is *nixi honi xuma*, meaning "vine from which the vision extract is made." Ayahuasca bark, which is often used in combination with members of the *Datura* genus, is the primary hallucinogen among many Amazonian tribes, being prepared as part of complex ritual ceremonies.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though known as a powerful hallucinogen, ayahuasca is also a medicine, being used as a remedy to cure a range of diagnosed conditions. However, ayahuasca is usually taken by the healer rather than by the patient. In the shamanistic societies of the Amazon, ayahuasca allows the healer to communicate with the spirit world where illness arises, interceding on behalf of the ill person and the community to restore health and harmony to all—quite unlike the individualized approach of Western medicine. Beyond its ability to affect mood, the bark is emetic and purgative. At low doses it is used as a mild detoxifier.

⚠️ **Caution** Ayahuasca is taken traditionally as part of a rich, complex ritual which affects the experience produced. Medicinal use of this plant is not advised.

Baptisia tinctoria (Fabaceae) Wild Indigo

Description Herbaceous perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has a smooth stem, clover-like leaves, and purplish-blue flowers in small terminal clusters.



Wild indigo, a North American plant, was used by the Penobscot to treat wounds.



Black horehound was an ancient Greek remedy for dog bites.